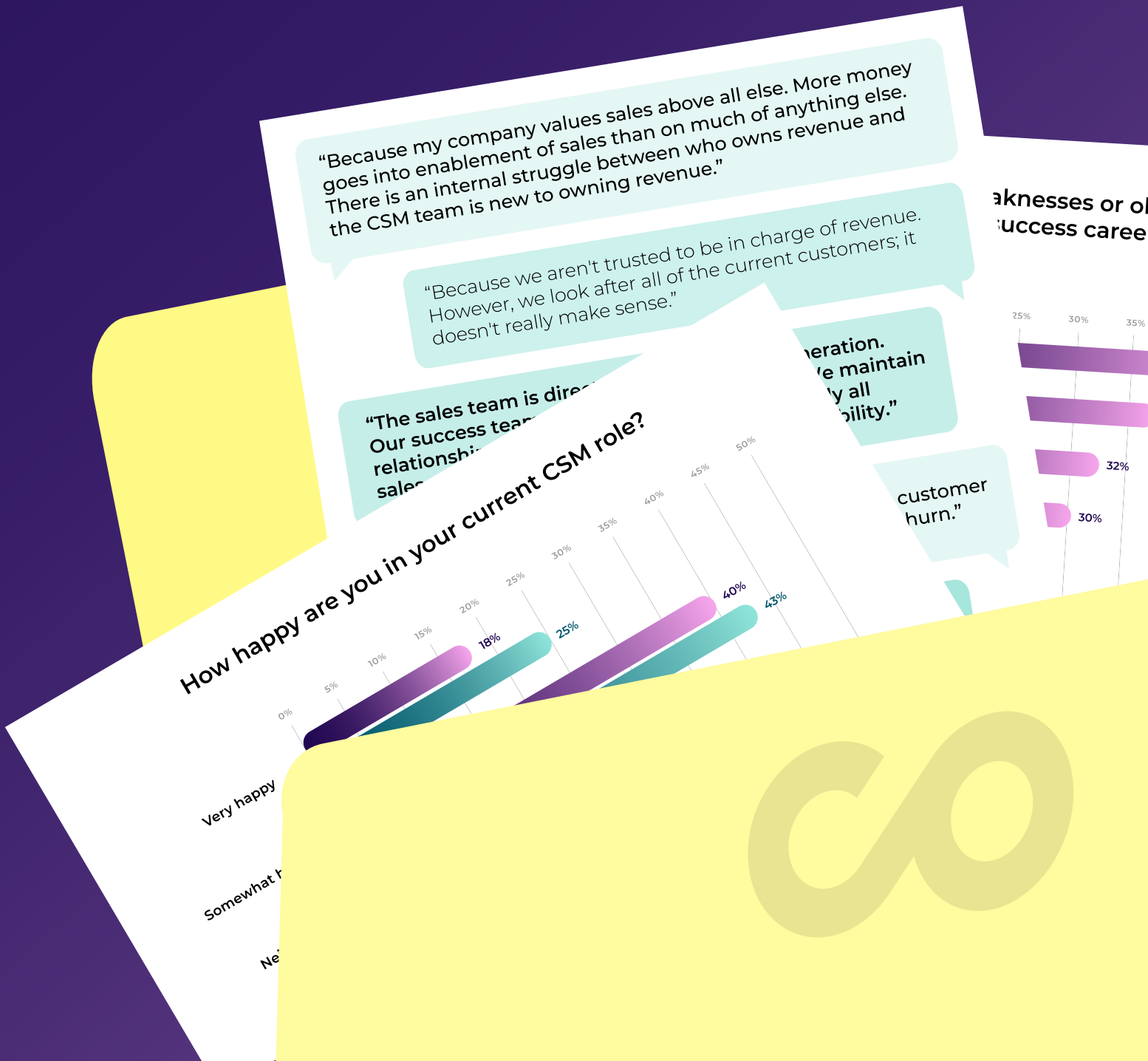
CHURNZERO

How to help CSMs get ahead in customer success

Actionable insights for customer leaders from the **2025 CSM Confidential Survey**



Your CSMs are dedicated drivers of your customers' goals and your company's growth. But how much do you know about their own goals and growth? And how could you support them better?

While last year's CSM Confidential Report focused on CSM workloads, this year's report focuses on how CSMs feel about getting ahead professionally. We asked 148 CSMs about their career goals, skills gaps, training opportunities, and readiness for leadership.

It's no surprise that CSMs are ambitious. They want a clear career path and the opportunity to grow. In today's SaaS economy, however, a direct path to career advancement is hard to provide.

Only one-quarter of our respondents say they see such a path in their current role, and 58% say they're likely to leave for a better opportunity if they find one. The downstream effects on many companies' customer experience, institutional knowledge, and team morale could be severe.

What can you do as a customer leader to retain your CSMs and nurture their growth?

This year, we enlisted five experts to dig into our survey findings and tell you. From learning and development best practices to alternative, non-leadership paths to career growth, you'll find their insights worthwhile and actionable, no matter where your team stands on the curve of CSM sentiment revealed by our survey.

Let's dig into what your CSMs might hope for and expect, and how you can arm them with the training, tools, and opportunities to grow.

Meet our expert contributors

ChurnZero partnered with five customer success experts to help analyze the survey findings and provide actionable perspective. We're grateful to:

Colby Bock
Director of Customer Success Program Delivery
ESG

Sabina Pons
CEO & CCO
Growth Molecules

Swati Garg
CEO
Melo Associates

Naomi Aiken
Founder and Principal Strategist
Techtonic Lift

Kristen Hayer
Founder & CEO
The Success League

Key findings

Most CSMs are happy in their day-to-day role. A majority of respondents are satisfied with their current CSM role, including 40% who are "somewhat happy" and 18% who are "very happy." Another 16% don't have strong feelings either way. Only one in four CSMs expressed dissatisfaction.

CSMs love working with their customers and teams. Most respondents say they enjoy getting to know their customers (87%) and helping them solve problems (86%). 80% say they appreciate their team, and nearly seven in 10 say they like and appreciate their manager.

CSMs have big aspirations. Nearly half of CSMs (45%) aspire to leadership roles and a further 16% aspire to a specialist CS role like customer success operations. Just 21% say their current CSM role is where they would prefer to be this time next year.

CSMs worry about their career paths. 53% of respondents say their employer does not have a "clear and achievable career path" for CSMs. Only 26% say they do. Further, only one-third of respondents (35%) feel like their employer is invested in their career.

Most CSMs will leave to get ahead. Nearly six in 10 indicated they will leave their current company if they find a better opportunity. A further 27% were "neutral" on this question. Just 15% said it was unlikely they would leave.

CSMs want and need more training. While 52% say they have the tools and training to accomplish their goals, most say their training opportunities are limited to online classes or ad hoc coaching by their managers. Their biggest pain point: sales and negotiation skills.

Sales teams get the glory, not CSMs. 59% of CSMs say their employer values the sales team more than the customer success team and just 6% say the opposite.

87%
of CSMs
enjoy getting to know their customers

59%
of CSMs
say their employer values the sales team more than the customer success team

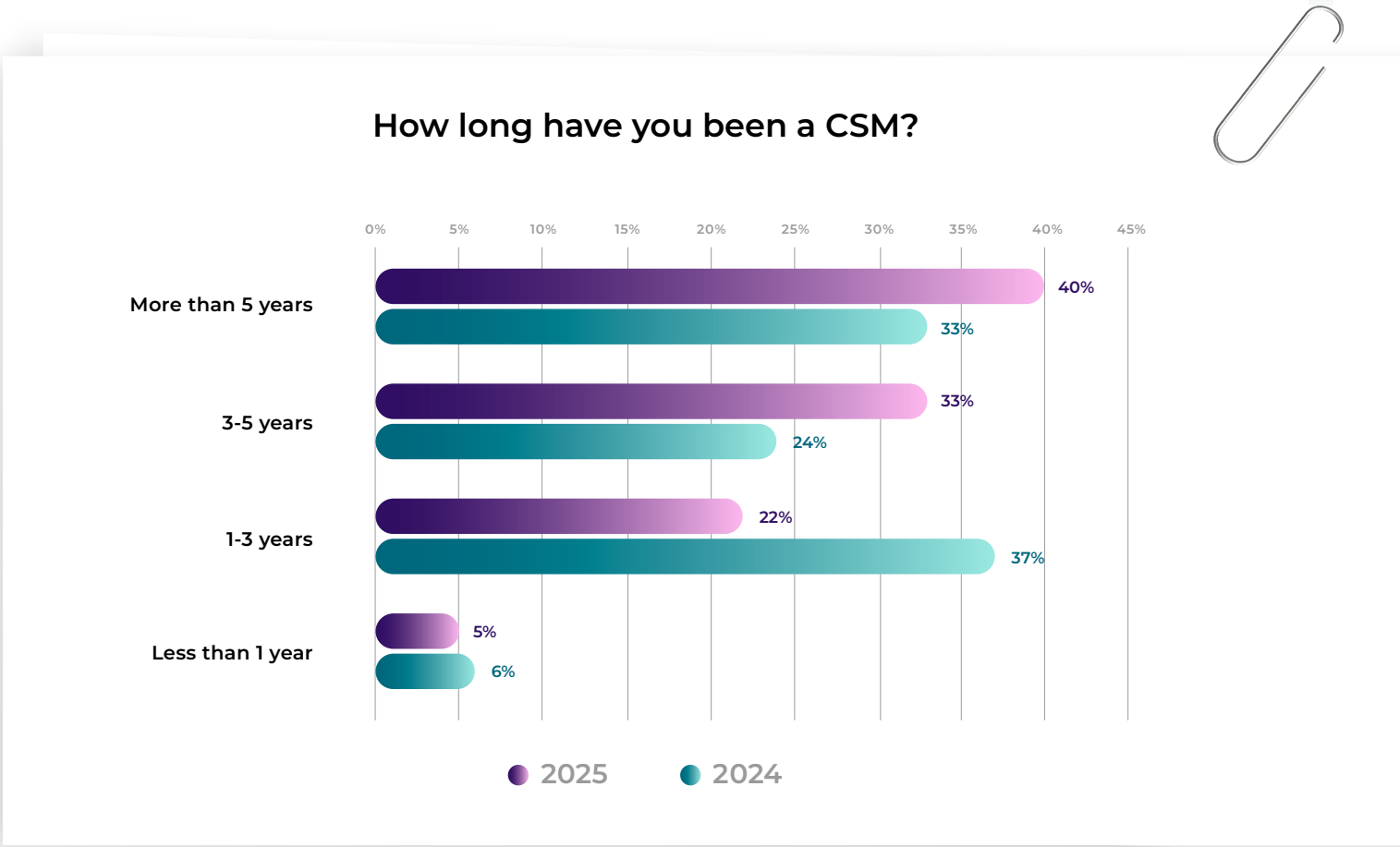
45%
of CSMs
aspire to leadership roles

1: CSM workforce experience and team size in 2025

The CSM workforce is growing more experienced, our data suggests, with a growing proportion accumulating three or more years on the job while team sizes remain relatively unchanged.

This year, 33% of respondents say they have 3-5 years of experience, a jump of 10% from last year. Similarly, 40% of 2025 respondents say they have five or more years of experience, an 8% increase from 2024.

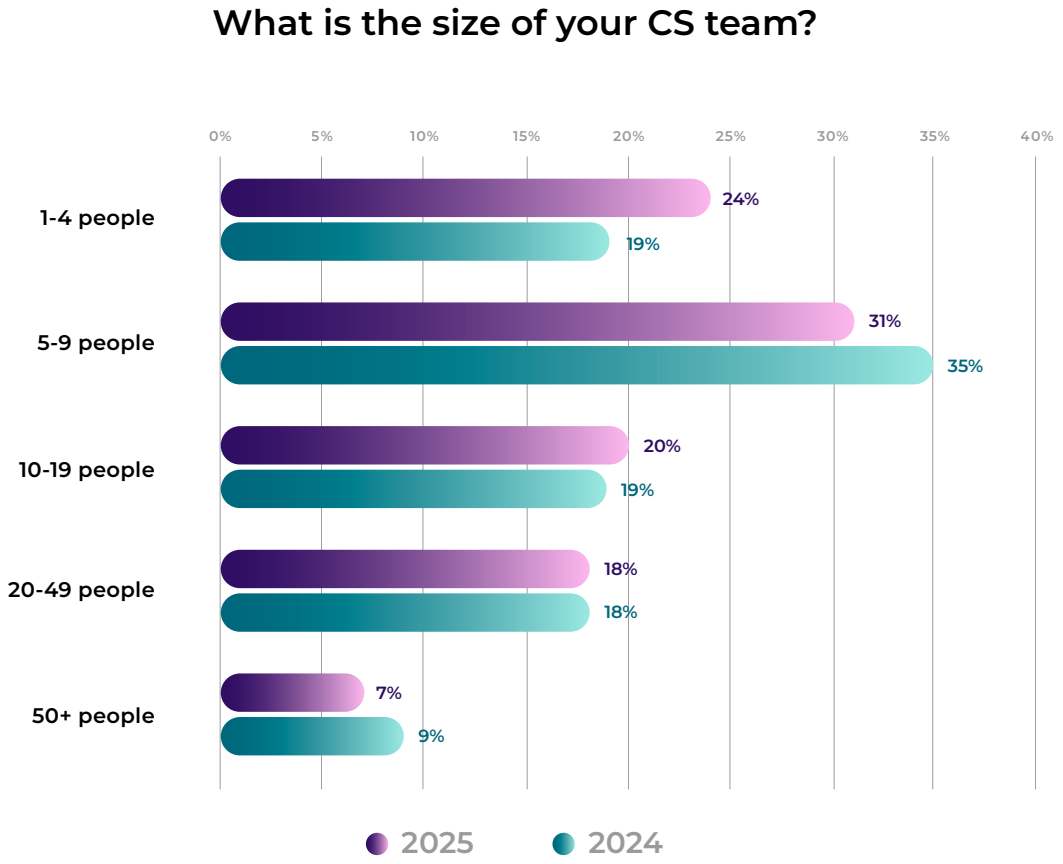
For SaaS companies, the trend represents a maturing talent pool, potentially with lower employee turnover. The flipside, however, is that CSMs may be feeling stuck due to lack of growth. What does that mean for longer-term employee morale and retention?



Colby: "Tenured CSMs are obviously good for customers and the company because they bring more knowledge and experience to the table.

Regarding team size, some may say, 'if it's not broken, don't fix it.' However, CS leaders should focus on the right KPIs and outcomes in their teams, asking themselves hard questions about their CSMs, the impact they make within the organization and with their customers. Revisiting the CS team structure at least annually is a good practice; however, most may take the hard look when they aren't meeting or exceeding KPIs."

Swati: "I speak with candidates every day and many people are open to leaving for the right opportunity in today's market. Without movement on their teams, there has been limited growth and development opportunities, so many are competing for those opportunities elsewhere and staying if they can't find them. Businesses need to regularly evaluate the skills the current team has gained in the last year, and where they want to go, and enable movement on the team and within the company."



Sabina: "As CSMs gain tenure, they bring sharper judgment, pattern recognition, and strategic foresight to customer interactions—qualities that directly impact retention, expansion, and advocacy.

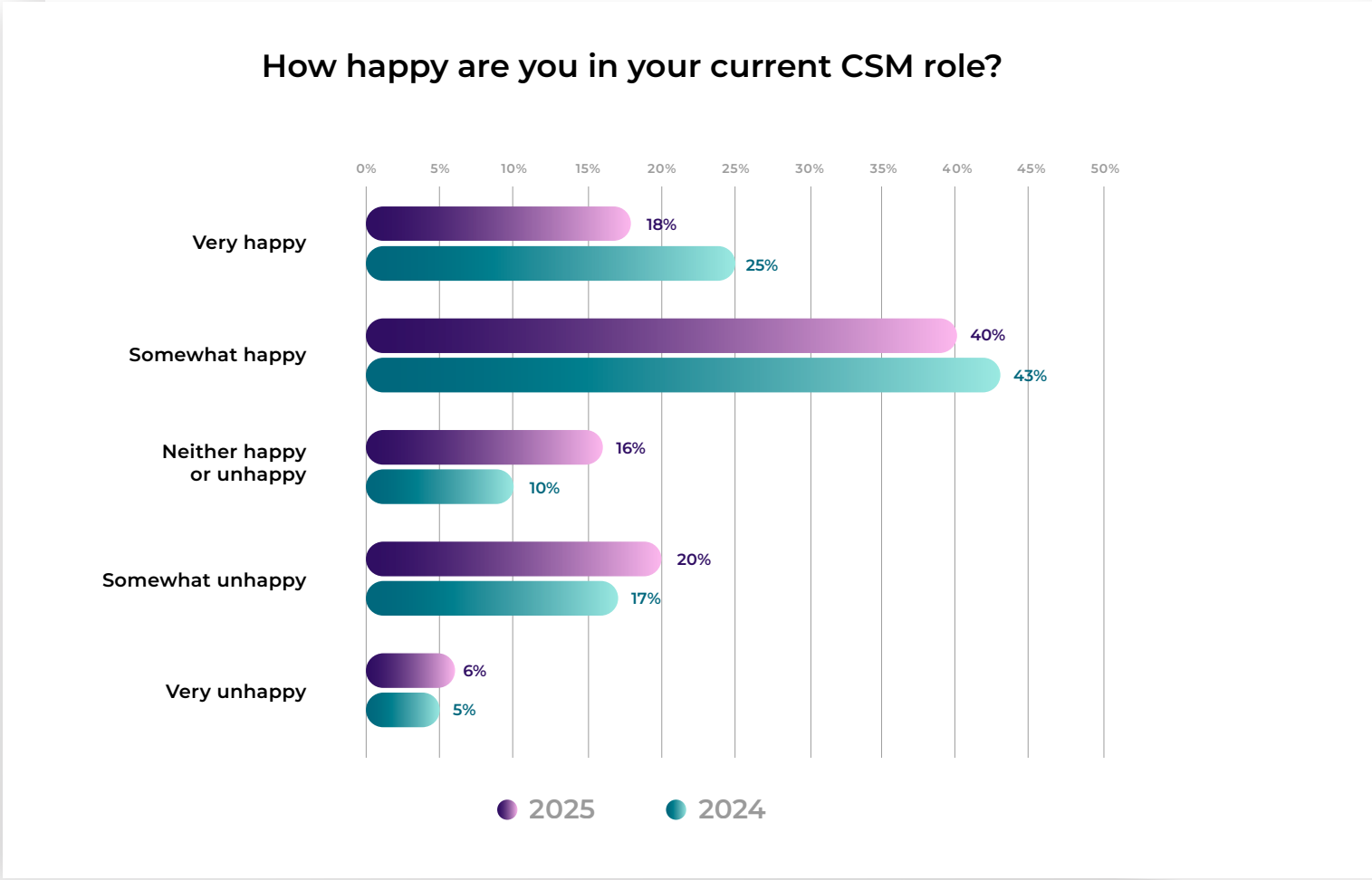
The data showing that CS team sizes have remained flat, while length of experience has grown, is a signal for companies to revisit team design and ask whether current roles still match business needs. Trigger points for re-evaluating team composition include changes in product complexity, shifts in go-to-market strategy, or signs of stagnant customer growth and satisfaction. Experience is a multiplier, but only when matched to the right team structure and evolving customer demands."

Naomi: "There are many reasons why CS team sizes are remaining the same—one being that, hopefully, teams are properly leveraging technology to make themselves more efficient. The tools available in the market are getting more sophisticated, automating so many previously manual processes that additional headcount is not always necessary.

The key with this approach, though, is that CS leaders reevaluate CSM job duties in tandem with the implementation of tools that increase efficiency, ensuring their current CSM headcount can continue to operate smoothly."

2: CSM satisfaction in 2025

This year, 58% of CSMs surveyed say they're very happy or somewhat happy in their roles, with a further 16% feeling neutral. 25% say they're somewhat unhappy or very unhappy in their role.

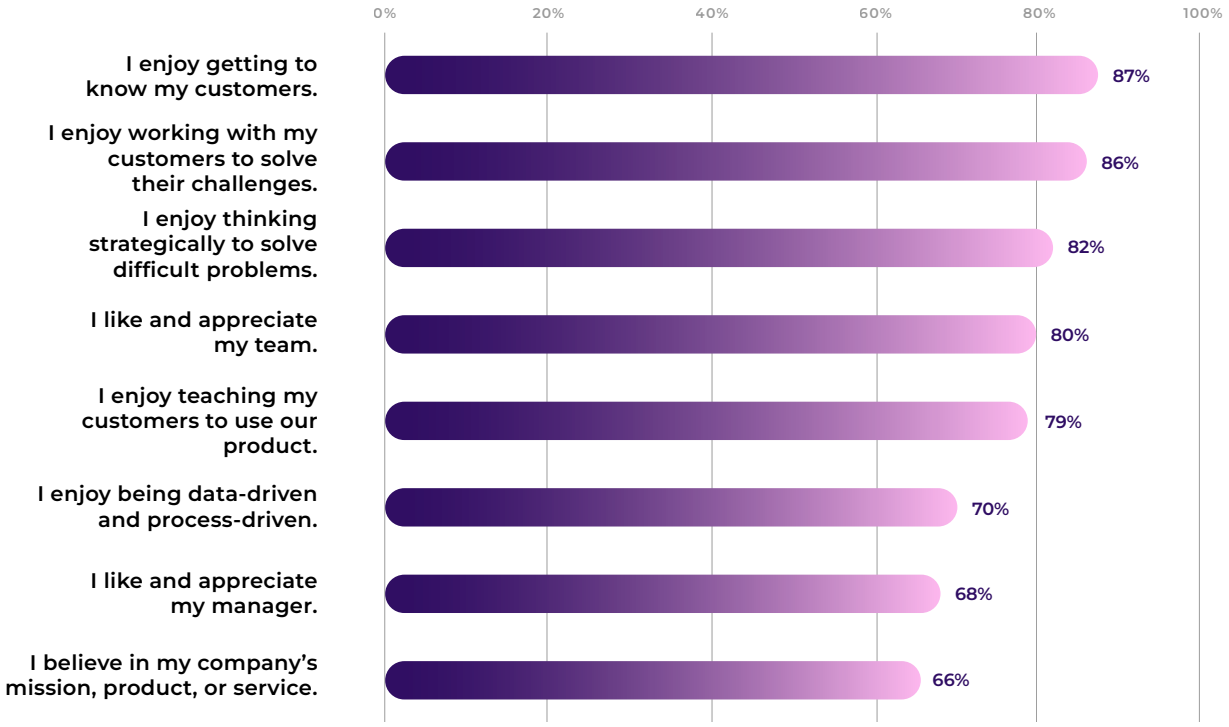


It's concerning that nearly every answer moved in the wrong direction this year, with the "happy" cohort losing 10% of respondents, the neutral group gaining 6%, and the combined "unhappy" cohort gaining 4%.

In a follow-up question for the "somewhat unhappy or very unhappy" group, we asked them why they were dissatisfied. The most common issues: 71% of unhappy CSMs feel like there's no room for professional growth at their organization. 68% say they feel burned out, and 66% say they feel underappreciated.

Sabina: "The downward trend in CSM satisfaction aligns with Gallup's 2025 State of the Global Workplace Report, which shows a broader global decline in employee engagement and wellbeing: both key drivers of productivity and innovation. It's not surprising that burnout, lack of appreciation, and limited growth opportunities are top concerns, as they directly undercut the factors Gallup links to stronger business outcomes. If customer success is meant to champion the customer experience, companies must prioritize the internal experience of their CS teams by investing in meaningful recognition, career development, and emotionally intelligent leadership."

What do CSMs enjoy about their roles in 2025?

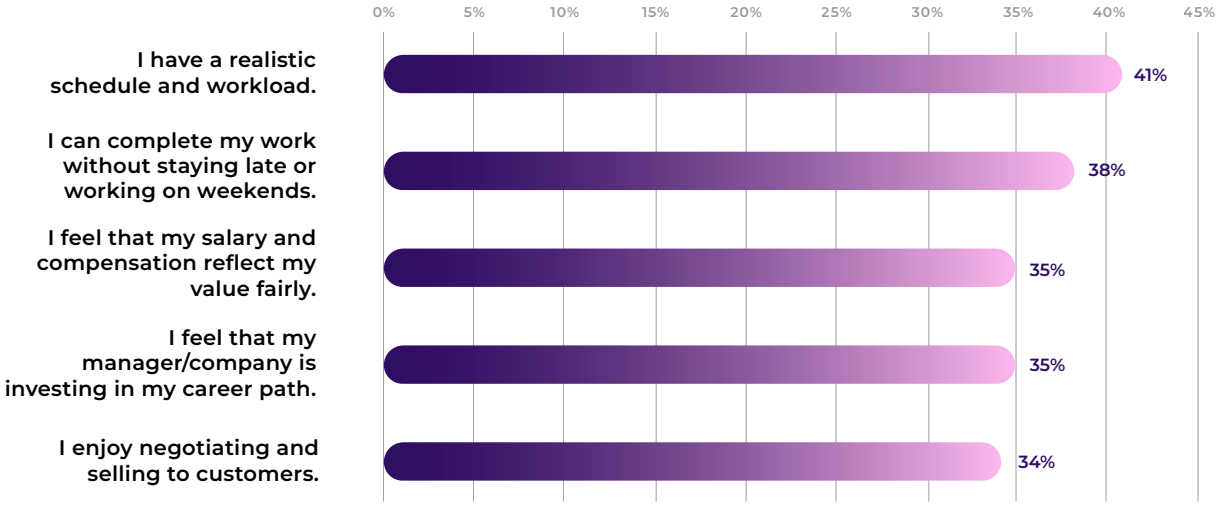


Kristen: "When we studied CSM tenure back in 2019, we found that the average tenure at that point was a little over two years. It doesn't surprise me six years, a pandemic, and an economic downturn later, those CS professionals might stick with their companies longer. But those companies have also struggled and often have not increased enough in size or scope to provide a robust career path.

CS leaders need to take a multi-faceted, realistic approach. Where there is no CS career path, consider a program that proactively places CSMs in other parts of the company that would benefit from their skills. That way, they have a path, and the company keeps the talent. Investing in training and development is also important, as is having a bench of talent so that when CSMs inevitably move on, you can quickly fill their places."

Swati: "Employee engagement directly impacts customers, and it is critical to keep them engaged and happy for a thriving business. There are so many ways to keep CSMs engaged and so many growth paths with the incredible and unique skill set that CSMs have that can be leveraged within the company, even if your CSM team isn't growing."

Causes for concern: workloads, career paths, compensation and selling.



Colby: "CSMs are often referred to as 'the cleanup crew' and can be understaffed, overworked, and left holding the cards post-onboarding. To ensure CSMs are set up for success and able to provide a true positive impact, companies need to support them.

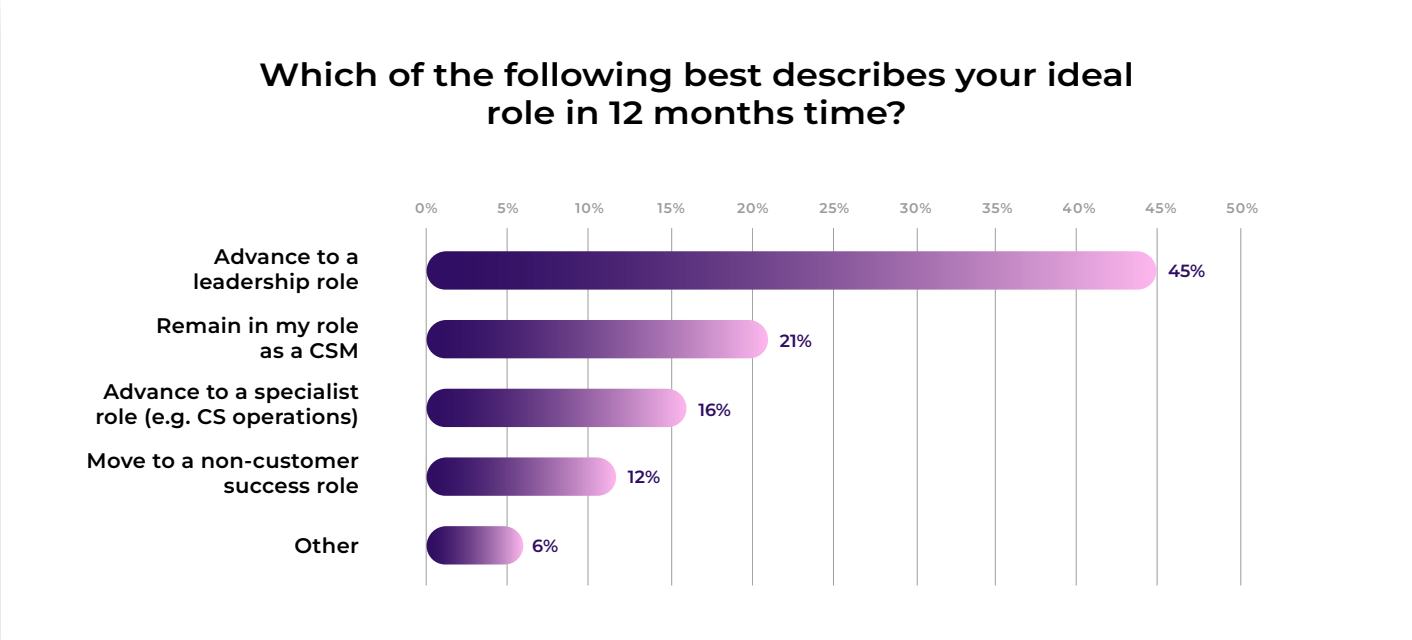
The people in your company who know the customers well will always be some of the most valuable employee assets. Get them the tools, training, and sophistication required to do the job and do it well. In return, you will see retention improve, referrals, up-selling and cross-selling grow, while driving job satisfaction up. Top it off with career advancement opportunities and you're off to the races!"

3: What are CSMs' career goals, and how realistic are they?

Nearly half of CSMs (45%) aspire to grow into leadership roles. This is at odds with the number one complaint among that cohort of unhappy CSMs: no clear path to professional growth. Overall, just 26% of CSMs say that their company has a clear and achievable career path for customer success managers.

Coupled with the fact that a majority of CSMs (58%) say they're likely or very likely to leave their role should the opportunity present itself, this is a warning sign for companies worried about employee turnover and its downstream effects on the customer experience.

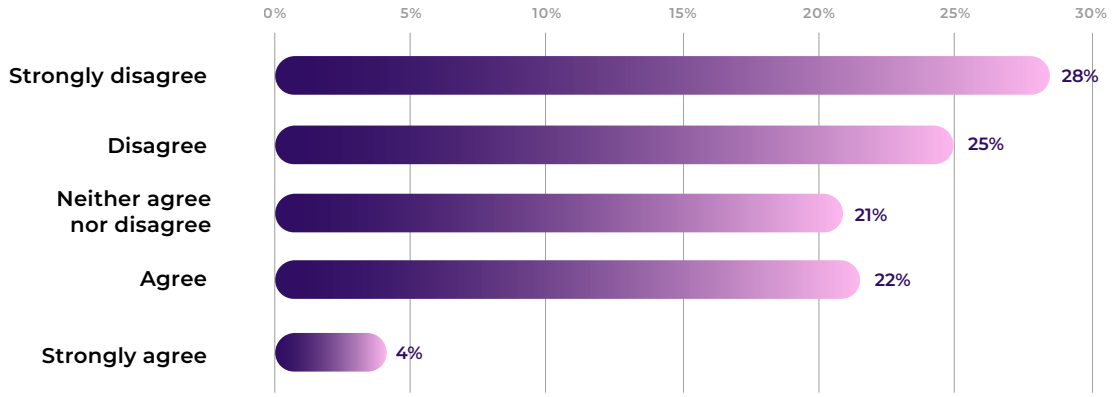
How realistic are CSMs' career ambitions in the current market? And, if upward movement is unlikely, how can leaders bridge the gap between expectations and reality with meaningful growth opportunities?



- **Colby:** "CS leaders need great CSMs to be great CSMs for as long as possible. That said, CSMs tend to get to a state of burnout due to multiple reasons. Solving some of the reasons will help, but for how long? Creating a proper career advancement program within the company and within the team will help. Not everyone will be able to be a manager. That said, people closest to your customers are some of the most valuable people in the company. There can be levels within CS. Supporting their growth will help performance, employee retention, and ultimately the brand."

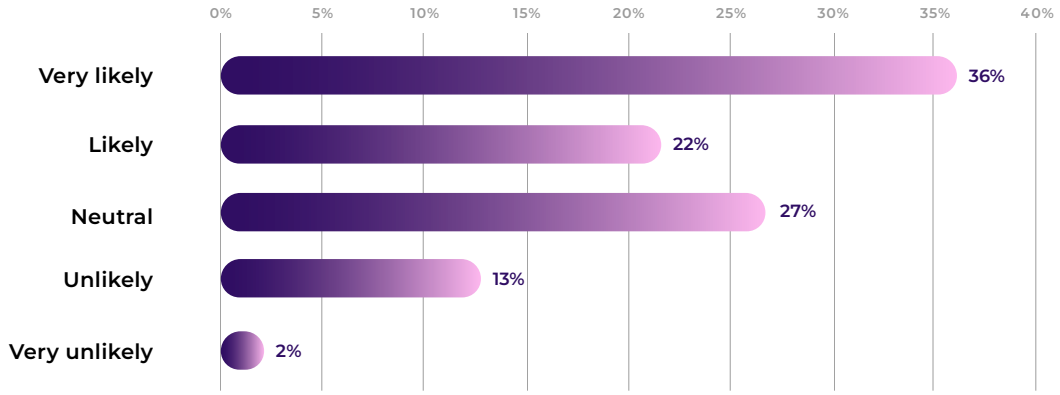
- **Kristen:** "According to the Gallup Employee Engagement study, which has been running for over 20 years, only one in 10 people has the natural talent for leadership and another two in 10 have the desire and ability to learn to be a strong manager. So, while 45% of CSMs want to move into leadership, only 30% actually should. I've noticed that management is often presented as the only way to advance, and that's why people think they have to pursue that path. We, as CS leaders, need to be talking about other options, especially options for advancing as individual contributors."

State your level of agreement: My organization has a clear and achievable career path for customer success managers.



Naomi: "Don't make your CSMs wonder about growth opportunities; tell them. It's not always the lack of career advancement available; often, it's the growth uncertainty that leads to dissatisfaction. Additionally, management is not the sole avenue for professional growth. Companies should be thoughtful in designing roles (and role titles) that motivate CSMs to stay CSMs or embrace lateral moves within an organization. For organizations that can offer leadership advancement, transparent career pathways with clear expectations at each level are essential for showcasing possible upward or lateral opportunities, and the steps required for each type of career progression."

How likely are you to switch companies if offered your ideal role elsewhere?



Sabina: "If a brand loses half of its CSM team, the impact is immediate and far-reaching. Customer relationships are disrupted, onboarding and renewal cycles suffer, and institutional knowledge walks out the door – costing far more than just backfill recruitment.

To retain ambitious CSMs, leaders must move beyond vague promises of growth and instead provide structured career paths that include lateral skill expansion, mentorship opportunities, and clearly defined milestones for advancement. The ideal CSM career track offers both management and expert individual contributor paths, empowering CSMs to grow in influence and compensation without feeling forced into leadership roles that may not align with their strengths or interests."

4: Where do CSMs need more training, and how do their employers support them?

The good news: half of CSMs (52%) say their organizations provide enough support, training and tools to reach their goals. The bad news: 13% say they've received no training at all in the last 12 months.

Online courses (45%) and occasional coaching (36%) by their manager are the most frequently cited training opportunities. Instructor-led training placed third on the list, but only for about one-third of respondents (32%): an underwhelming volume for a business discipline that's clamoring for professional development and career growth.

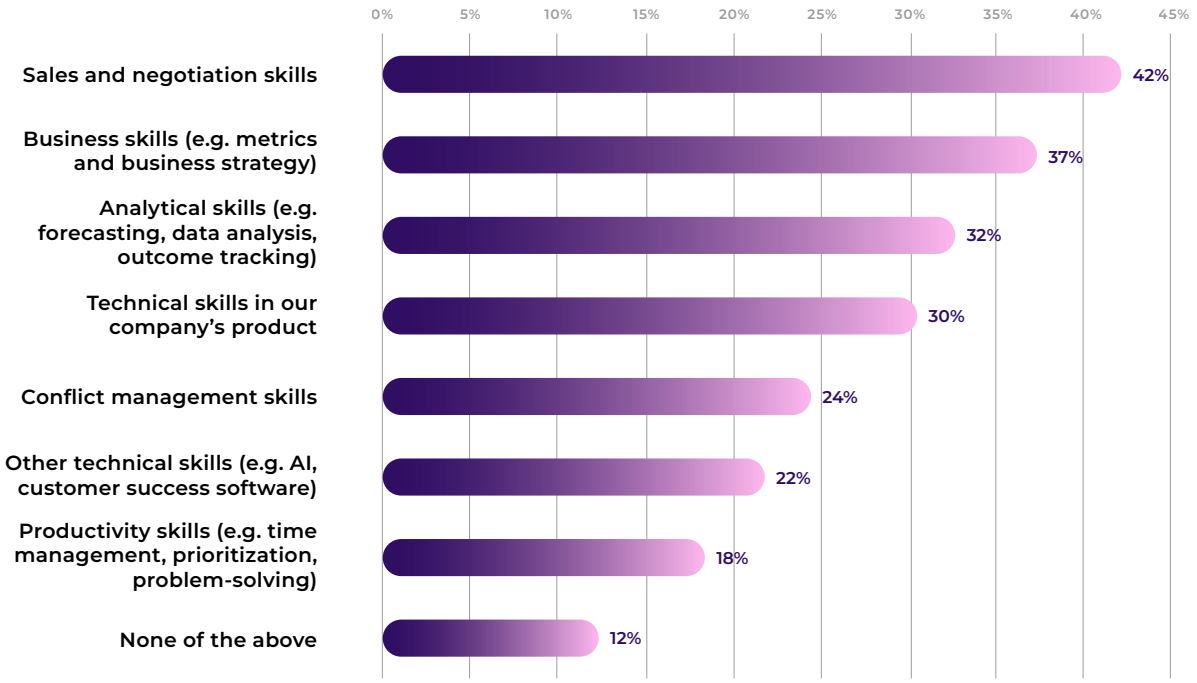
Kristen: "There are a couple of things driving this. First, often the managers are still carrying a customer base of their own. The practice of making someone a 'lead' and giving them a team while still asking them to keep a set of customers is rampant and very unrealistic. Both the team and the customers suffer because the lead's attention is divided. Thus, they never really have time to do the work it takes to keep their team engaged. Second, most managers never receive training in management basics—conducting one-on-ones, coaching, and delegating—so they aren't sure how to engage their team members. Both of these things result in a big disconnect between what the manager thinks is going on, and what CSMs are actually thinking."

Sabina: "Leaders absolutely need to partner with HR and L&D to co-create strategic programs, but individual supervisors can also foster growth through simple, grassroots efforts: hosting lunch-and-learns, assigning rotating team leads for initiatives, or facilitating group debriefs after industry webinars.

For self-driven CSMs, low-cost development includes joining CS communities, subscribing to expert newsletters, volunteering for cross-team collaboration, or even conducting peer-led skill shares—small steps that signal initiative and build both competence and confidence."

Of all the skills that CSMs recognize they need more training in, sales and negotiation top the list. Given that CSMs are well-positioned to influence renewals, cross-selling and upselling, such training could have an immediate impact on the results they yield.

Which of these skills do you consider weaknesses or obstacles to getting ahead in your customer success career? Select all that apply.



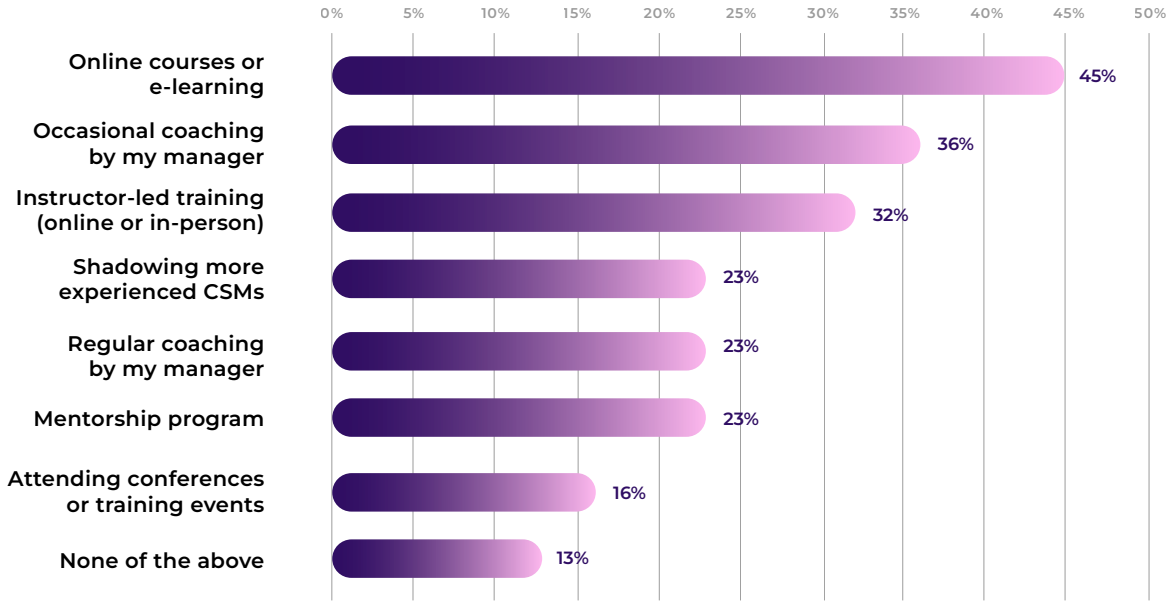
Kristen: "The top three reasons our customers pursue training through our programs are:

1: To improve their selling skills (asking questions, negotiation, handling objections).

2: To improve their ability to engage at the strategic, executive level (communication, business strategy, research).

3. To become more value-focused and proactive: e.g., setting goals, cross-functional planning, time management. Companies are still moving people into CS from related disciplines like account management and support. These CSMs often have great company and product knowledge but lack skills in these three areas."

Which of these training experiences, specific to customer success, has your company provided within the last 12 months? Select all that apply.

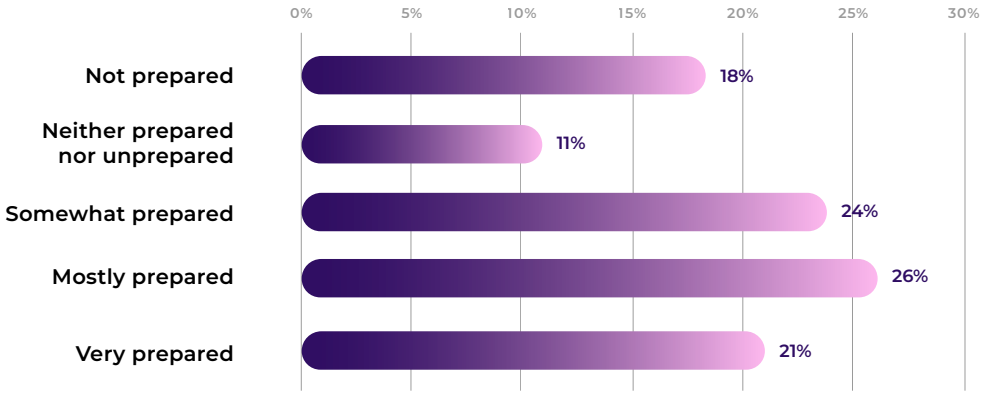


Sabina: "These results mirror what I see across many B2B tech organizations: training is often ad hoc, underfunded, and focused more on product than on developing the strategic, commercial, and leadership skills CSMs need to thrive. The companies that invest intentionally in structured L&D—especially in sales, negotiation, executive presence, and data storytelling—consistently report higher renewal rates, faster time-to-value for new hires, and improved internal mobility. Sales and negotiation training isn't hard to deliver when prioritized, and when paired with coaching and practice-based reinforcement, it becomes a powerful lever for both CSM confidence and revenue impact."

Naomi: "An impactful approach to training involves actively seeking CSM input on the specific growth and development opportunities they need. Recognizing that different CSM teams have distinct needs—some may require forecasting support, while others prioritize technical skills—employers should actively engage in these conversations. When executive leaders directly engage with individual contributors to understand their development needs, the resulting collaboration benefits both the individuals and the organization."

When asked if they feel prepared for a leadership position, about half of CSMs (47%) said they are. This suggests many CSMs are confident in their abilities and simply want a chance to prove it to their employer. It's also worth noting that 29% don't feel prepared, and a hesitant 24% feel just "somewhat prepared." This is a signal to employers that their learning & development (L&D) programs require attention.

If you were promoted immediately to a leadership position within your team, how prepared would you feel to succeed?



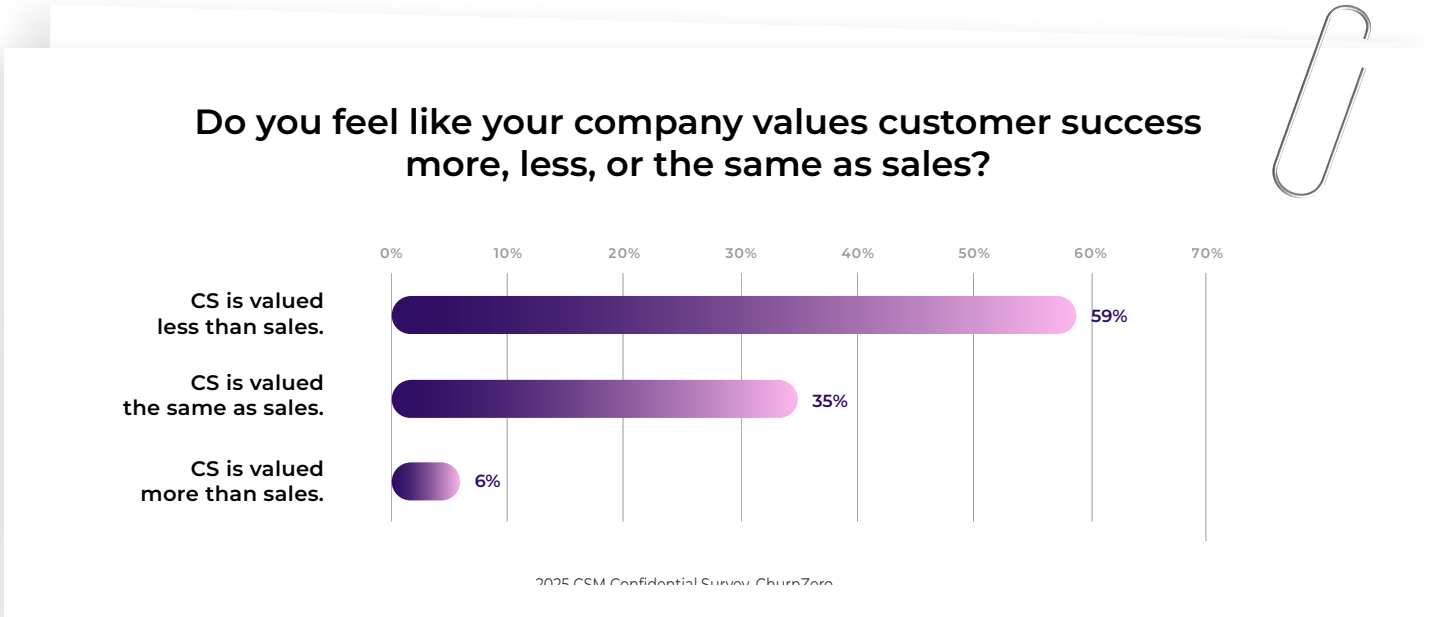
Naomi: "While CSMs often aspire to promotions and upward mobility, their readiness for leadership roles varies significantly across organizations. Given that a concerning proportion of CSMs report receiving no initial training, it's likely they lack adequate preparation for the demands of CS leadership. The very skills CSMs identify as needing more training—negotiation, metrics, forecasting, and business strategy—are crucial for leadership success. Companies should offer hands-on CS leadership training opportunities, enabling them to evaluate leadership potential and identify CSMs who are truly ready for management responsibilities."

5: Do CSMs feel less valued than their sales colleagues?

This year, we asked CSMs whether their company values customer success more, less, or the same as sales. We followed this with an optional, open-ended question asking why.

Nearly six in 10 respondents (59%) feel like their sales team is more valued than their customer success team, while 34% say the teams are valued equally. 6% say CS is valued more. You'll see some of the reasons given for each answer below.

Given the importance of customer retention in compounding growth and company valuation, why would a majority of CSMs say they're valued less than their sales counterparts at work?



Kristen: "I don't think that we, as CS leaders, have always done a good job of drawing the line between the work we do and the revenue it produces. Your team doesn't have to sell to produce revenue, but you, as a leader, need to identify and quantify the areas where your team delivers value to your company. By teaming up with sales and finance leaders, you can build the bridges it takes to be seen as a contributor of revenue. Sometimes that also means taking a strong stance about how your team is presented in leadership and board meetings. Your contribution needs to be highlighted to senior leaders and investors for the company to see and acknowledge the value of CS."

Why we're valued less than sales (59%): a sample of CSM answers.

"Because my company values sales above all else. More money goes into enablement of sales than on much of anything else. There is an internal struggle between who owns revenue and the CSM team is new to owning revenue."

"Because we aren't trusted to be in charge of revenue. However, we look after all of the current customers; it doesn't really make sense."

"The sales team is directly tied to revenue generation. Our success team does not sell or negotiate. We maintain relationships and train customers, but ultimately all sales-related tasks are the sales team's responsibility."

"Sales sells a product that isn't a good fit, but customer success gets blamed when those customers churn."

"They have combined the teams which isn't really helping anyone."

"We care more about the initial sale win, not the retention."

Naomi: "If CSMs feel undervalued or unsupported, customer experience will inevitably suffer. Just as neglecting sales team resources would be unthinkable, so too should proactive attention to CSM well-being be a top priority, rather than a reaction to a crumbling foundation.

As the daily point of contact for your customers, the importance of your CSMs is on par with any other revenue-generating team, requiring the same level of investment in tools and training to drive positive results. Valued and supported CSMs directly contribute to customer satisfaction and retention."

Why we're valued the same as sales (34%): a sample of CSM answers.

"Both are valued in different ways. For example, the sales team is more valued for bringing in new revenue and growing the business. CS is valued for customers' success and them being fans of the product on social media, referring new customers to us and CS being the guardian of revenue."

"Every department has a function that supports the organization. All are different but valuable in different ways."

"We are the main revenue generator right now, so we have a lot of leadership attention to be sales agents. We still don't get a lot of the resources that Sales team gets, but the pressure is the same."

"The sales team is viewed as a 'money making organization'. CSMs cost the company money. However, I do believe that the CSM's 'gut feeling' in regards to risk is highly valued."

"Company leadership verbalizes that our CS dept is a market differentiator and has heavily invested in the dept in the past few years, but there's a treatment of elevated status for the sales team."

"Our renewal and expansion efforts are equally recognized by management when we discuss results. Our compensation model also reflects that. Additionally, when we had layoffs some time ago, the sales team wasn't treated as an exception. I also believe we receive equal support from the RevOps team.

Sabina: "Companies should view customer success as a revenue engine—not just a support function—critical for driving retention, expansion, and long-term customer lifetime value, especially in recurring revenue models like SaaS. To prove value, CS leaders must consistently tie their team's outcomes to commercial metrics such as churn reduction, upsell conversion, and net revenue retention.

Bridging the sales-CS divide requires aligned incentives, shared success metrics, and regular joint planning. When both teams co-own the customer lifecycle and celebrate mutual wins, collaboration becomes the default, not the exception."

6: What do CSMs say about how to get ahead in customer success?

For our final question, we asked CSMs for a career tip they've learned so far. What advice would they offer a junior employee for getting ahead in their customer success career?

Here's a sample of what they offered.

"Advocate for yourself. Do your own learning if it's not provided (block out time to learn about your own product or skills needed to be a CSM). If CSMs are not taken seriously in the business, don't take it personally."

"Learn product first."

"Attach to a senior member of the team. Local product knowledge is the primary recognition of customers to have faith and confidence in their customer success partner."

"Learn to use your platform deeply. Each client will have slightly different use cases or priorities, and this will help you tailor your trainings and communications to them."

"Be curious and ask questions to understand. Learn as much as you can outside of your role. Be willing to take on additional projects to advance your learning but be careful to set clear boundaries to protect your workload."

"Identify ways to stand out and be your own advocate. Say yes to interesting opportunities."

"Invest time in deeply understanding your product and how it delivers value across different use cases. Build a consistent discovery framework—like a go-to set of questions—that helps uncover each customer's unique goals, challenges, and workflows."

"Learn as much as you can about the product, how the organization's teams work together, and your clients."

"Make A.I. your best friend—this will be invaluable moving forward and help you get ahead 100x and be a leader on your team. Speak your mind with constructive feedback and you will become a natural leader within your organization. Sales is important in CS, and something you should become as comfortable with as possible."

"Start by mastering your core responsibilities: drive product adoption, support change management, and secure renewals. Once those become second nature and your process gives you back time, look for ways to go beyond."

"Work for a company whose product you love and that you truly believe brings value to your customers."

"Work in sales first, so you understand why customers buy your product and what are the challenges your product solves."

Resources for CSMs and new leaders

As your platform and partner for customer growth, we're dedicated to helping CSMs and customer leaders get ahead in customer success. We hope you'll take advantage of these free resources.

For CSMs:

Carve your own career path in customer success: Learn the specialized career paths available to CSMs and which skills you'll need to level up to leadership.

How to master tough talks for CSMs: Learn to navigate tense renewal negotiations, advocate for yourself and your career goals, and turn conflicts into win-win outcomes.

The top 1% CSM blueprint: Discover five everyday work habits and productivity techniques that the industry's most effective CSMs employ.

How to have better goal-setting discussions: Identify the most important skills and strategies for your career growth and connect them to your company's business outcomes.

For new customer leaders:

The essential mindset shift for effective CS leadership: Build the mindset and confidence to stop people-pleasing and become a proactive, strategic leader.

What your CSMs need from you to succeed: Dig into the findings of 2024's CSM Confidential report with actionable tips to help your team overcome stress, build their skills, and thrive.

Make the leap from first-time manager to leader: Learn to anticipate the challenges that most new managers don't, motivate your team, and drive outstanding results.

About ChurnZero

ChurnZero is the platform and partner for customer growth. Our software provides game-changing capabilities to understand, strengthen, and grow your customer relationships, enabling you to drive revenue repeatably and efficiently at scale.

Along with product innovation, we're known for our partnerships with customers. Your team gets award-winning customer success, training, implementation guidance, and support to help you deliver the best possible customer experience and build more revenue.

Find out more at **churnzero.com.**